

Easter Offensive: An Loc

The area between Saigon and the Cambodian border, known as Military Region 3, was crucial for South Vietnam: it formed a safety belt for Saigon and contained most of the country's industry. The North Vietnamese made it the focus of their Easter Offensive.

◀◀ BEFORE

The area around An Loc had been the scene of several battles between the US and communist forces earlier in the war.

PAST CLASHES

A Viet Cong attack in Loc Ninh province in October 1967 diverted US and South Vietnamese forces from the real threat of the [Tet Offensive](#). In March 1969, the United States First Infantry Division and 11th Armored Cavalry Regiment fought a tough battle against the NVA in the abandoned Michelin rubber plantation at An Loc to stop its advance south toward Saigon.

BATTLE READY?

NVA forces, and the Viet Cong in particular, were relatively inexperienced at fighting as a conventional force. During the early stages of the war, they largely used [guerrilla tactics](#). American troops had led combat before [Vietnamization](#), so ARVN troops were also relatively new to the role.

It is thought that Hanoi's objective in Military Region 3 (MR 3) was to strike down Route 13 from the Cambodian border and storm Saigon. Initial proposals to make it the main focus of the offensive, however, were changed because of supply problems.

Cardboard tanks

The assault opened on April 2, 1972, with a diversion—an NVA regiment advancing toward the province of Tay Ninh. The North Vietnamese had even placed cardboard T-54 tanks opposite the city of Tay Ninh to convince South Vietnamese leaders that the attack would come there. In fact, the real attack began three days later, when North Vietnamese General Tran Van Tra led his main force of three divisions from Cambodia into Binh Long province. The NVA Seventh Division aimed to block Route 13 and isolate the battlefield, while other forces conquered the province and prepared for the pursuit south into Saigon.

Colonel William H. Miller, senior US adviser to the ARVN Fifth Division, responsible for this part of MR 3, was not fooled by Tran Van Tra's diversions but he was not able to convince his South Vietnamese counterpart, Brigadier General Le Van Hung, to concentrate his forces on Binh Long.

On April 5, General Tra sent two regiments supported by two dozen tanks plus heavy artillery, to Binh Long's town of Loc Ninh, just north of the province capital of An Loc. US Army gunship helicopters, Navy carrier aircraft, Air Force close support planes, and Vietnamese planes all responded, but on April 6, Tra's Seventh Division blocked a section of Route 13, and surrounded Binh Long province. Loc Ninh fell to the Viet Cong's Ninth Division on April 7, making An Loc, the NVA's next target.

The ARVN had scattered groups of its Fifth Division across the province, which General Tra's forces took some time to drive back. President Thieu summoned a full division, the 21st, from MR 4 (south of Saigon), to block the road to Saigon, while bringing up the ARVN First Airborne Brigade to back the An Loc defenders. Colonel Tran Van Nhut, the province chief, who had been at a conference when the attacks started, hastened to An Loc to reorganize the available Regional Forces troops. General Hung also received the Third Ranger Group as a reinforcement. An Loc's garrison and the town of 15,000 had to be supplied by air.